mean an enduring national triumph.'[139] In reiterating this view, *The Hindu* provided a more elaborate argument:

> The steamer service between Tuticorin and Colombo is of the greatest importance to us. Tuticorin at present is practically the only decent port for most of the southern districts of the Presidency. Ceylon takes a large quantity of the rice produced in the Tamil districts, while Tinnevelly cotton finds a ready port of shipment in Tuticorin. There is a large colony of South Indian merchants in Colombo and other towns in Ceylon, while the number of cooly emigrants thereto is annually increasing. Moreover, Colombo is an important port on the great highway of Asiatic commerce and the vessels belonging to every line touch there on their way to the Far East and Australia. The importance of the Tuticorin–Colombo connection cannot therefore be over-estimated, the present unsatisfactory character of the Tuticorin port notwithstanding. For the monopoly of the traffic between Tuticorin and Colombo, the Swadeshi and B.I.S.N. are *rival* competitors, though the self-constituted deputation from Tinnevelly tried its best to obscure this fact. Each of the competitors feels that one of them will, in the long run, have to give in. Judged by its history during the last two years the Swadeshi Company is not likely to be the first to give in. At its back lie the determination of a patriotic band of merchants and others in Tuticorin and Colombo, and the strength derived from the gathering volume of national sentiment throughout the country.[140]

Meanwhile, several BI's consignees in Colombo met in mid-July and decided to boycott its services. While the anger against the draconian sentence on VOC was the proximate reason, the underlying reason was that their consignments were being systematically tampered with. The police blamed this protest on 'the Tuticorin vakil gang' who, it was claimed implausibly, 'hoped to raise interest in the company and sell more shares'![141]

Apart from strengthening the Tuticorin–Colombo line, SSNCo now planned to explore the ports on the Coromandel Coast. Its plan to extend the service to Nagapattinam received a fillip from the Colombo protest. BI did not take this talk lightly and promptly despatched an agent from Colombo to see what it was all about.[142]

Exploiting the potential for coastal trade was not easy. Discharging outstanding debts apart, at least Rs 1 lakh was required as working capital. As we saw above, the company met only with limited success towards meeting this target. We do not know how the new capital of Rs 1,25,000